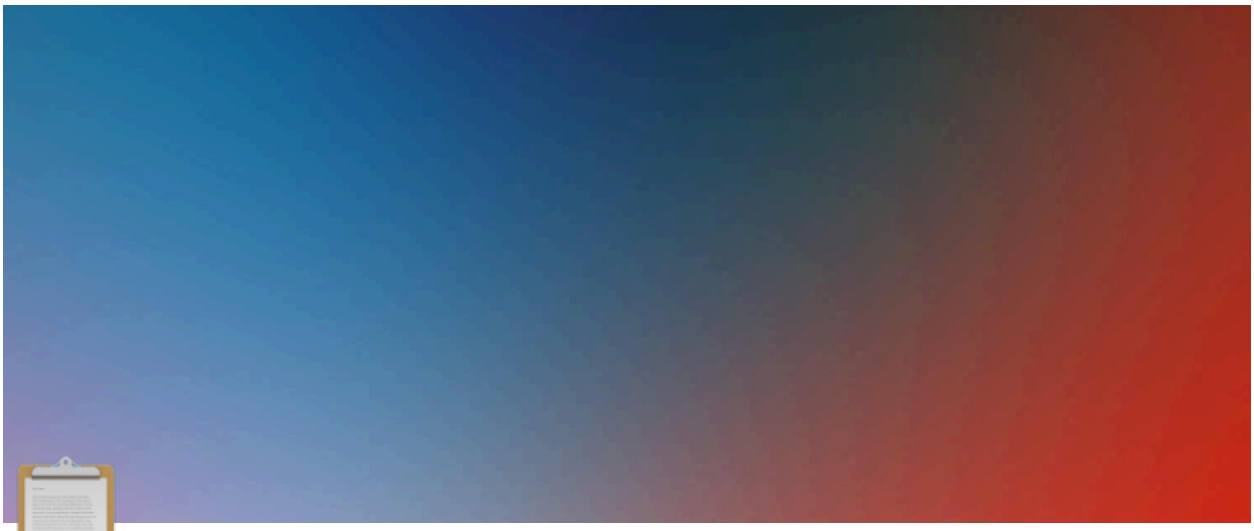


# Project Plan - Dating App

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# Description of the project

Our project is about creating a new dating app. Many people use dating apps, but they often complain about things like being too focused on looks, safety issues, or boring conversations.

We want to design an app that feels safer, more fun, and helps people connect in a real way. First, we'll do research on users and other apps, then make a prototype in Figma, and finally build the app in Xcode using SwiftUI.

# Team members

Here is the list of the team members.

**Team for project**

| Team member | Role | Responsibility |
|---|---|---|
| @Георги Балабанов | Product | UX/Ui design, Research and App development. |
| @Jan Hristov | Product | UX/Ui design, Research and App development. |

# Team agreements

### Communication and Contact

We'll use **Discord** for daily chats and updates, and **Trello** to keep track of tasks. For meetings with teachers, we'll use **Microsoft Teams**. All our files and notes will be in **Notion** or **Microsoft 365**, and if we need quick replies, we'll message each other on **social media apps**.

### Core Values

Our team values are pretty simple: respect each other, share the work fairly, and be honest about deadlines or problems. We'll help each other out when needed and focus on learning while building something cool, not just on the grade.

### Team Responsibilities

Both of us will work on research, design, and coding. We'll swap tasks sometimes so we both learn different things. Both of us will  keep **Trello/Notion** up to date, also will handle **teacher communication**.

### Tools & Documentation

We're using **Trello** for tasks, sprints and project plan, **Notion** for notes, **Figma** for designs, and **Xcode with SwiftUI** for coding. **Firebase** will handle login/chat, and **Microsoft 365** will be for reports and presentations.

### Attendance & Meetings

We'll do weekly check-ins, mainly in class and also online, daily updates on Discord when working. If someone can't make it, they'll let the other know. Meeting notes will go in **Notion** so we don't forget what was discussed.

| Tool / Platform | Purpose / Use Case |
|---|---|
| Trello | Task management and project phases tracking |
| Discord | Daily communication and quick updates |
| **Microsoft Teams** | Meetings with teachers / Documentation upload |
| Notion | Documentation, notes, and research results |
| **Microsoft 365** | Reports, presentations, and shared documents |
| Figma | Wireframes, mockups, and clickable prototypes |
| **Xcode (SwiftUI)** | App development (frontend) |
| **Social Media (e.g., WhatsApp/Messenger)** | Fast replies and emergency contact |

# Goal of the project

### Research & Understand Users

Collect insights through surveys and interviews.

Identify frustrations with current dating apps.

Summarise opportunities for improvement.

**Plan & Define Features**

List the core features every dating app needs.

Brainstorm unique features (activities, compatibility score, icebreakers).

Sketch the app flow to map how users will move through the app.

**Design the Prototype**

Create wireframes for all main screens.

Sketch the app flow to map how users will move through the app.

Turn wireframes into high-fidelity designs in Figma.

Make the prototype clickable and testable.

Refine design based on feedback from teachers and users.

**Develop the App**

Build the app in Xcode using SwiftUI.

Implement authentication, profiles, matching, and chat.

Add unique features like activity-based matching or icebreaker prompts.

Connect to a backend (Firebase) for login and chat.

**Test & Improve**

Test the app with classmates.

Collect feedback and fix bugs.

Improve user experience before final review.

# Research and analysis

### 1. User Research

- Conducted a **survey** and **interviews** targeting users aged **18–24** to understand their needs, frustrations, and expectations.
- **Key findings:**

- Most participants have **used dating apps** but **many stopped** due to dissatisfaction.
- **Top goals:** casual dating, finding serious relationships, and social interactions.
- **Main frustrations:**
  - Low match quality
  - Fake profiles and bots
  - Safety and harassment concerns
  - High paywalls limiting essential features
  - Poorly optimized matching algorithms
- **Desired features:**
  - Strong **profile verification**
  - **AI-driven matching** based on interests and values
  - **Interactive elements** like mini-games, polls, and events
  - Fairer pricing models and reduced paywalls

## 2. Research questions ( Click here to see the document )

- Research goals

We want to:

1. Learn what users like and dislike about dating apps.
2. Check what current apps (like Tinder, Bumble, Hinge) are doing well and where they fail.
3. Find ideas for unique features that could make our app stand out.
4. Collect enough information to guide our design in Figma and then the coding stage in Xcode.

- Main research question

How can we design a dating app that provides safer, more engaging and different from the usual boring apps, and meaningful connections for users aged 18–24?

- Sub research questions

To keep the project plan concise, we've summarised the main focus areas of our sub-research questions:

- **User Needs & Behaviours** - Understand why young adults use dating apps and what they expect.
- **Pain Points & Frustrations** - Identify common problems like fake profiles, safety issues, and poor match quality.
- **Matching & Interaction Preferences** - Explore how users prefer to discover matches and start conversations.
- **Safety & Verification** - Investigate which features make users feel safer and build trust.
- **Engagement & Retention** - Find out what features could make the app more fun and keep users coming back.

### 3. MoSCoW Prioritisation

We used the **MoSCoW method** to prioritise features based on user needs and feasibility.

| Priority | Features |
| --- | --- |
| **Must Have** | - Secure user authentication - Profile creation & verification - AI-driven matching - Swipe or scroll-based discovery - Private chat with safety controls |
| **Should Have** | - Icebreaker prompts & AI-suggested openers - Shared-interest suggestions - Basic reporting and blocking tools |
| **Could Have** | - Mini-games, polls, and interactive events - Group activities or meet-up suggestions |
| **Won't Have (for MVP)** | - Advanced premium filters - Complex location-based event systems |

This ensures the **MVP** focuses on the **core experience** while leaving advanced features for later stages.

### 4. Competitor Analysis

| App | What's Good | What's Not So Great | What We Can Learn |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Tinder** | Super popular, fast swiping, lots of users | Too focused on looks, lots of ghosting | Keep it simple, but make it feel more meaningful |
| **Bumble** | Women send the first message, safer vibes | Some features locked unless you pay | Give users control, maybe add safety tools |
| **Hinge** | Meant for real convos, uses profile prompts | Takes more time to use, slower matching | Add questions or prompts to help start conversations |
| **Badoo** | Global reach, video chat, profile checks | UI is a bit messy, lots of ads/premium stuff | Keep layout clean, and only paywall non-essential features |

- **Tinder:** Widely used but criticized for **shallow interactions** and **pay-to-win mechanics**.
- **Hinge:** Focuses on prompts and deeper connections, but some users find it **algorithmically random**.
- **Bumble:** Promotes safety by letting women message first but has **limited personalization features**.
- **Key takeaway:** Current apps fail to balance **trust, safety, personalization, and engagement** effectively.

Most apps today either feel too focused on looks (like Tinder), or they **make users do too much work** just to connect (like Hinge). Some are trying cool things like **verification** or **video chat**, but not everyone wants that.

> **Ideas that we can implement into the dating app that would make it different from the others:**

1. Voice - only first impressions : Instead of swiping on photos, users hear a 10-second voice intro and pick based on personality.

2. Matching by shared music : Match users based on their current top songs or Spotify vibe.
3. Blind reaction game? : Each day you get 3 mystery profiles with NO photos. You just respond to their prompts. After you both react, photos unlock.

### 5. Personas

We created **five diverse user personas** based on our survey insights to better understand the needs, frustrations, and motivations of potential dating app users. These personas — ranging from **serious relationship seekers** and **casual explorers** to **safety-focused users**, **social connectors**, and **skeptical non-users** — help us design features that cater to different behaviors and expectations. By considering these personas, we ensure the app addresses **trust, safety, engagement, and personalization** effectively.

| Archetype | Persona | Behavior | Motivation | Key Needs |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **The Relationship Seeker** | Emily | Seeks serious connections | Meaningful relationships | Verified profiles, AI-driven matching |
| **The Fun Explorer** | Alex | Casual use, enjoys socializing | Entertainment & new experiences | Interactive features, shared-interest matching |
| **The Safety-First User** | Priya | Cautious, prioritizes safety | Secure dating & control | Multi-step verification, safety tools |
| **The Social Connector** | Lucas | Uses app for friendships | Building community | Activity-based matching, group events |
| **The Skeptical Non-User** | Sarah | Avoids apps, privacy-driven | Trust & authenticity | Transparent policies, value-based matching |

### 5. Market Insights

- Online dating is **highly popular** among young adults, but **trust and safety** remain major concerns.
- Users want **better quality matches** and **less transactional experiences**.
- There is an **opportunity** to build an app that:
  - Combines **AI-driven personalization** with **fun, interactive features**
  - Implements **strong safety measures** and **verified profiles**
  - Offers a **fair pricing model** without locking essential features behind paywalls

### 6. User Personas

Based on survey insights, we defined **personas** to guide feature design:

**Persona 1 — The Serious Dater**

- **Age:** 22
- **Goal:** Looking for a meaningful, long-term relationship.
- **Frustrations:** Low match quality, fake profiles.
- **Needs:** **Verified profiles**, **AI-powered matches**, and **better filtering options**.

**Persona 2 — The Casual Explorer**

- **Age:** 20
- **Goal:** Wants fun conversations, casual dating, and trying new experiences.
- **Frustrations:** Paywalls, boring profiles, and ghosting.
- **Needs:** **Interactive features** like mini-games and **icebreaker prompts**.

**Persona 3 — The Safety-Conscious User**

- **Age:** 21
- **Goal:** Open to dating but priorities **safety** and **privacy**.
- **Frustrations:** Harassment, catfishing, and scam accounts.
- **Needs:** **Strong verification**, **reporting tools**, and **in-app video chat** before meeting.

### 7. Key Opportunities

- **Trust & Safety:** Establish trust through **robust verification systems** and **real-time moderation**.
- **Better Matching:** Use **AI-powered suggestions** based on shared interests and deal-breakers.
- **Engagement & Retention:** Integrate **interactive features** like mini-games, polls, and group events.
- **Fair Monetisation:** Offer a **freemium model** where essential features remain free but premium perks are optional.

# Major requirements & deliverables

- **User Accounts & Profiles**
  - Sign up/login (email, phone, or social).
  - Profile creation with photos, bio, and interests.
- **Matching System**
  - Browse/discover other profiles.
  - Like/Pass functionality.
  - Show when two users match.
- **Chat System**
  - Messaging between matched users.
  - Basic features: text, emojis, notifications.
- **Unique Features**
  - Activity-based matching or interest-based suggestions.
  - Icebreaker prompts/conversation starters.
  - Safety options (report, block, profile verification).

- **Design**
  - Wireframes for all main screens.
  - High-fidelity Figma prototype with clickable flow.
- **Technical Setup**
  - Built in Xcode with SwiftUI.
  - Backend (e.g., Firebase) for authentication and chat.
  - Tested and working core features.

# Methodology

Scrum is an agile project management framework that organizes work into iterative cycles called sprints, typically lasting 1-4 weeks. During each sprint, team members collaborate to complete prioritized tasks from a project backlog, delivering incremental progress and continuous feedback.

We will follow a step-by-step process to design and develop the dating app. Our workflow is split into phases:

1. **Research Phase**
   - Collect insights from surveys, interviews, and competitor analysis.
   - Summarise findings to understand user needs and problems with current dating apps.
2. **Ideation Phase**
   - Define the core features every dating app needs.
   - Brainstorm unique features to make our app different.
   - Sketch a simple app flow to show how users move between pages.
3. **Design Phase (Figma)**
   - Create low-fidelity wireframes for all key screens.

- Turn wireframes into high-fidelity mockups with colors, icons, and fonts.
- Build a clickable prototype and test it with users.
- Improve the design based on feedback.

4. **Development Phase (Xcode/SwiftUI)**
    - Set up the Xcode project and environment.
    - Build the main features: login, profiles, discovery, matching, and chat.
    - Connect a backend (Firebase) for authentication and chat functions.
    - Add unique features such as activity-based matching and icebreaker prompts.
5. **Testing Phase**
    - Test the app with classmates and collect feedback.
    - Document bugs and issues.
    - Improve the user experience and fix problems.
6. **Final Presentation / Assessment**
    - Prepare slides and demo video (optional).
    - Present the process from research to final app.
    - Highlight unique features and improvements.

# Human-Centered Design

Human-Centered Design (HCD) is a design methodology that prioritises the needs, behaviours, and experiences of end-users. This approach involves empathy-driven research and iterative design phases, where feedback from users is continually gathered and incorporated. The goal is to create solutions that are functional, accessible, and deeply relevant to the people who will use them, ensuring greater adoption and satisfaction.

# DOT framework

- **Field Research –** Observing and gathering insights directly in real-world environments to understand user behavior in natural contexts.
- **Library Research –** Reviewing existing literature, theories, and models to build a foundational knowledge base for the project.
- **Workshop Research –** Collaborating with stakeholders in workshops to co-create solutions, ensuring alignment with user expectations.
- **Lab Research –** Testing and prototyping in controlled settings to evaluate technical components and functionality.
- **Showroom Research –** Presenting near-final prototypes for user feedback on usability and overall experience before full deployment.

# Success factors

The success of our project will depend on how well we can move through each phase and deliver what we planned. It is not only about building an app but also about making sure the process — research, design, development, and testing — is done properly. To measure success, we will look at whether our app meets user needs, includes unique features, works technically, and is presented clearly at the end.

- **Clear Research** – We gather enough insights from surveys, interviews, and competitor analysis to understand what users really want from a dating app.
- **Unique Features** – The app includes at least one feature that makes it different from existing apps (e.g., activity-based matching, icebreakers, safety tools).
- **Usable Prototype** – A working Figma prototype that shows the full user flow and is easy to navigate.
- **Working Core App** – An Xcode project where the main features (sign-up, profiles, matching, chat) are functional.
- **User Feedback** – We test the app with classmates and get positive feedback about usability and experience.

- **Teamwork** – Both team members contribute and communicate well, staying on schedule with Trello.
- **Final Presentation** – We present the whole process (research → design → development → testing) in a clear way to teachers.

# Risks and mitigations

**1. Data Privacy & Security**

- **Risk:** Sensitive user data could be exposed through breaches.
- **Mitigation:** Use **end-to-end encryption**, secure authentication, GDPR compliance, and regular security audits.

**2. Fake Profiles & Bots**

- **Risk:** Scammers and bots reduce trust and engagement.
- **Mitigation:** Enable **multi-step verification**, AI-based bot detection, and **verified profile badges**.

**3. Harassment & Safety Issues**

- **Risk:** Users may face harassment, stalking, or abuse.
- **Mitigation:** Provide **report/block tools**, real-time moderation, **in-app video chats**, and **public meeting reminders**.

**4. Low Match Quality**

- **Risk:** Poor matches frustrate users and reduce retention.
- **Mitigation:** Use **AI-driven personalization**, refine algorithms, and allow **custom filters** for better control.

**5. Scalability & Performance**

- **Risk:** High traffic could cause app lag, crashes, or downtime.
- **Mitigation:** Use **cloud infrastructure**, load balancing, and plan **scalability** from the start.

# Milestones & schedule

Manage tight deadlines required by listing out specific milestones, their status, and who's the point person. Click into each card to add notes and do the work right inside.

↓ Click Timeline view to create and see other views of your milestones.

**Timeline**

| Name | Date | Lead | Status |
|---|---|---|---|
| Milestone #1 | @September 29, 2021 → October 3, 2021 | Andrea Lim | Completed |
| Milestone #2 | @October 1, 2021 → October 5, 2021 | Ben Lang | In progress |
| Milestone #3 | @October 3, 2021 → October 7, 2021 | Nate Martins | Not started |

# Assumptions & constraints

This is where we compile all known and unknown variables.

- **Assumptions (Knowns)** → things we expect to be true and can plan around.
- **Constraints (Unknowns / limits)** → things we're not sure about yet or things that may hold us back.

## Known

- We will be working in a team of two for the whole project.
- The app will be developed using **Xcode with SwiftUI**.

## Unknown

- How many people will respond to our survey or interviews.
- Whether all planned features can be fully implemented within the timeframe.

- Firebase will be used for authentication and chat.
- Teachers expect research, Figma prototype, and a working app demo as deliverables.
- Classmates can be used as test users for feedback.
- Possible technical issues (e.g., Firebase setup, SwiftUI bugs).
- How much guidance/feedback we will get from teachers at each phase.
- If unique features (like activity-based matching) can be built at MVP level.